Knowledge Cutoffs, Temporal Knowledge Boundaries, and Citation Reliability in Large Language Models

A Controlled Comparative Study of Explicit Publication-Date Instructions

Research Report

Knowledge Cutoffs, Temporal Knowledge Boundaries, and Citation Reliability in Large Language Models

Abstract

Large language models are increasingly used to support academic literature reviews, but generated references may not respect a researcher's intended publication-date boundary. This study investigates whether adding an explicit temporal instruction changes the publication-date compliance of generated literature reviews.

A controlled comparative design was used, consisting of five matched prompt pairs and ten generated reviews. Condition A used a standard literature-review prompt, while Condition B included an explicit instruction to cite only scholarly works published on or before 31 December 2024. A total of 99 citation instances were extracted and assessed.

Condition A contained 15 post-cutoff citations among 51 references, producing a post-cutoff rate of 29.41%. Condition B contained no post-cutoff citations among 48 references. The mean paired reduction was 29.64 percentage points. A sensitivity analysis restricted to bibliographically matched references retained a mean paired reduction of 27.14 percentage points.

The findings suggest that explicit publication-date instructions may improve observable temporal compliance in generated literature reviews. However, the small sample and unresolved bibliographic cases require cautious interpretation. The study measures compliance with an explicit date constraint rather than the model's internal knowledge cutoff.

Keywords: Large language models, knowledge cutoff, temporal knowledge, citation reliability, literature review, hallucination, bibliographic verification.

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1. Introduction

Large language models (LLMs) are increasingly used in academic research for summarizing literature, identifying relevant studies, and drafting literature reviews. These capabilities can reduce the time required for preliminary research. However, the reliability of generated academic references remains an important concern.

One particular challenge involves temporal knowledge boundaries. A researcher may require a literature review to include only studies published before a specified date. A generated review may nevertheless include references published after that date, potentially because the model does not consistently follow the intended temporal scope.

Citation reliability also involves more than publication dates. References may contain incorrect titles, author information, publication venues, or digital object identifiers (DOIs). A citation can refer to a real work while still containing inaccurate metadata.

This study examines whether an explicit publication-date boundary instruction can improve the temporal compliance of generated literature reviews. It also examines bibliographic verification outcomes to distinguish date compliance from reference accuracy.

1.1 Research Problem

When a language model generates a literature review without a clearly stated publication-date restriction, it may include works published after the researcher's intended cutoff date. This can create problems for historical reviews, systematic literature searches, and research requiring a fixed temporal scope.

The study therefore investigates whether an explicit date-boundary instruction reduces the occurrence of post-cutoff citations.

1.2 Research Question

Does adding an explicit publication-date boundary instruction reduce post-cutoff citations in literature reviews generated by a large language model, and how does this affect bibliographic reliability?

1.3 Research Objectives

• Compare citation-date compliance under standard and explicitly constrained prompts.

• Identify references published after the specified cutoff date.

• Assess the bibliographic consistency of generated references.

• Compare outcomes across five matched prompt pairs.

• Examine whether the observed pattern remains when unresolved references are excluded.

1.4 Scope

The study uses a publication-date cutoff of 31 December 2024, inclusive. It compares two prompting conditions using ten generated literature reviews. The findings concern observable compliance with the stated temporal boundary and do not directly establish the model's internal training-data cutoff.

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2. Research Methodology

See `docs/METHODOLOGY.md` for the complete methodology.

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3. Results and Findings

See `results/RESULTS_AND_FINDINGS.md` for the full results, tables, and figure references.

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4. Discussion, Limitations and Conclusion

See `docs/DISCUSSION_LIMITATIONS_CONCLUSION.md` for the complete discussion, limitations, and conclusion.

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5. Reproducibility and Supporting Materials

The accompanying project repository contains citation extraction datasets, bibliographic audit records, statistical analysis outputs, figures, and experimental documentation.

The generated literature reviews and analysis records are retained to support inspection and reproducibility. Bibliographic verification decisions and publication-year classifications should be interpreted according to the limitations documented in the methodology and results.

3. Research Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This study employed a controlled comparative design to investigate whether explicit publication-date boundary instructions influence the temporal compliance of large language models when generating literature reviews.

Two prompting conditions were compared. Condition A used a standard literature-review prompt. Condition B used the same underlying prompt with an additional instruction requiring the model to include only scholarly works published on or before 31 December 2024, inclusive. The instruction also required uncertain publication dates to be omitted or flagged rather than guessed.

The experiment consisted of five matched prompt pairs, producing ten literature reviews in total.

3.2 Experimental Conditions

Condition A: Standard Prompt

The model received the standard literature-review prompt without an explicit publication-date restriction.

Condition B: Explicit Temporal Boundary

The model received the same underlying literature-review prompt, preceded by an explicit instruction to respect the publication-date boundary of 31 December 2024. The instruction specified that

unverified publication dates should not be guessed.

The comparison was designed to isolate the effect associated with adding an explicit temporal boundary instruction.

3.3 Data Collection

Ten literature reviews were generated manually through the ChatGPT user interface. The five matched pairs were identified using pair IDs P01 through P05.

The generation order was randomized using seed 2026. The generated reviews were saved as Word documents and subsequently converted into text files for analysis.

The model selector label and visible generation settings were recorded in the generation log.

The generated reviews were retained for analysis. Their observed lengths exceeded the originally intended target of 800–1,000 words. This deviation was documented rather than modifying the generated outputs after collection.

3.4 Citation Extraction

References were extracted from the bibliography sections of the generated literature reviews. The extraction process identified candidate bibliography entries and assigned run IDs and reference numbers to support traceability.

The initial extraction identified 100 candidate entries. One entry was determined to be commentary rather than a complete bibliographic reference. The final analysis therefore considered 99 reference instances.

3.5 Bibliographic Verification

Candidate references were assessed using bibliographic metadata services, including Crossref and OpenAlex, together with additional record checks where appropriate.

Manual decisions were recorded using four categories:

• MATCH: the bibliographic record was identified and considered consistent with the cited reference.

• PARTIAL_MATCH: a record was identified, but one or more bibliographic details remained inconsistent or unresolved.

• DOI_MISMATCH: a discrepancy involving the cited DOI was identified.

• NOT_APPLICABLE: the entry was not a complete bibliographic reference.

A failed DOI lookup was not treated as sufficient evidence that a reference was fabricated. Preprint and published versions were also distinguished where relevant.

3.6 Temporal Classification

The temporal boundary was set to 31 December 2024, inclusive.

References were classified according to their candidate publication year:

• WITHIN_CUTOFF: publication year on or before 2024.

• POST_CUTOFF: publication year after 2024.

• UNKNOWN_DATE: publication year could not be established.

Publication-year candidates and independently verified dates were distinguished in the audit records. Where a preprint and a later proceedings or journal version differed, the cited version was relevant to the cutoff assessment.

3.7 Evaluation Measures

The primary outcome was the proportion of dated citation instances published after the cutoff:

Post-cutoff rate = Post-cutoff citation instances / All dated citation instances

The secondary outcome was bibliographic match rate:

Bibliographic match rate = MATCH instances / All analyzed citation instances

A sensitivity analysis was also conducted using only references classified as MATCH.

3.8 Paired Analysis

Results were compared within each of the five matched prompt pairs. For each pair, the post-cutoff citation rate under Condition A was compared with the corresponding rate under Condition B.

The mean paired reduction was calculated as the average of the five pair-specific differences.

Given the small number of matched pairs, the analysis emphasized descriptive comparisons and cautious interpretation rather than strong claims of statistical generalizability.

3.9 Research Limitations

The experiment involved five matched pairs and ten generated literature reviews. Consequently, the findings should not be assumed to generalize to all language models, prompts, or subject areas.

The study measured observable compliance with an explicit publication-date instruction. It did not directly measure the model's internal training-data cutoff or establish the exact boundary of its internal knowledge.

Manual bibliographic assessment and publication-version distinctions also introduce potential uncertainty. These limitations were retained when interpreting the results.

4. Results and Findings

4.1 Overview of the Dataset

The experiment generated ten literature reviews across five matched prompt pairs. Citation extraction initially identified 100 candidate bibliographic entries. One entry was classified as commentary rather than a complete reference, leaving 99 citation instances for analysis.

The references were classified according to the publication-date boundary of 31 December 2024, inclusive.

4.2 Overall Temporal Compliance

Condition A produced 15 post-cutoff citations among 51 citation instances, corresponding to a post-cutoff rate of 29.41%.

Condition B produced no post-cutoff citations among 48 citation instances. All 48 were classified as within the publication-date boundary.

Measure	Condition A	Condition B
Citation instances	51	48
Within cutoff	36	48
Post cutoff	15	0
Unknown year	0	0
Post-cutoff rate	29.41%	0.00%

The observed difference in post-cutoff rates was 29.41 percentage points in favour of Condition B.

4.3 Bibliographic Verification

The manual bibliographic audit classified the 100 extracted candidate entries as follows:

Decision	Number
MATCH	93
PARTIAL_MATCH	5
DOI_MISMATCH	1
NOT_APPLICABLE	1
Total	100

Among the 99 actual reference instances, 93 were classified as MATCH. The remaining six consisted of five partial matches and one DOI mismatch.

Condition A had 45 MATCH entries among 51 citation instances, giving a bibliographic match rate of 88.24%.

Condition B had 48 MATCH entries among 48 citation instances, giving a bibliographic match rate of 100%.

These results describe the manual audit decisions and should not be interpreted as proof that every bibliographic detail is error-free.

4.4 Matched-Pair Comparison

The five matched pairs were compared using their respective post-cutoff citation rates.

Pair	Condition A	Condition B	Reduction
P01	30.00%	0.00%	30.00 pp
P02	30.00%	0.00%	30.00 pp
P03	30.00%	0.00%	30.00 pp
P04	18.18%	0.00%	18.18 pp
P05	40.00%	0.00%	40.00 pp
Mean	29.64%	0.00%	29.64 pp

Every matched pair showed a lower post-cutoff citation rate under Condition B. The mean paired reduction was 29.64 percentage points.

4.5 Sensitivity Analysis

A sensitivity analysis was conducted using only references classified as MATCH in the manual bibliographic audit.

This restricted analysis retained 45 confirmed references in Condition A and 48 in Condition B.

Measure	Condition A	Condition B
Confirmed references	45	48
Within cutoff	33	48
Post cutoff	12	0
Post-cutoff rate	26.67%	0.00%

The mean paired reduction in post-cutoff rates was 27.14 percentage points. All five matched pairs continued to show a lower rate under Condition B.

The sensitivity analysis therefore supports the consistency of the descriptive pattern when unresolved bibliographic cases are excluded.

4.6 Statistical Interpretation

All five matched pairs showed a reduction in post-cutoff citation rates under Condition B.

A two-sided exact sign test based on the five pairwise directions gives p = 0.0625. This does not meet the conventional 0.05

significance threshold.

The sample contains only five matched pairs. Accordingly, the results are interpreted primarily as descriptive evidence rather than conclusive statistical proof.

4.7 Summary of Findings

The principal findings are:

• Condition A produced a post-cutoff citation rate of 29.41%.

• Condition B produced a post-cutoff citation rate of 0%.

• All five matched pairs favoured Condition B.

• The mean paired reduction was 29.64 percentage points.

• The confirmed-reference sensitivity analysis retained a reduction of 27.14 percentage points.

• Condition B had a higher bibliographic match rate in this sample.

Overall, the results indicate that adding an explicit publication-date boundary instruction was associated with improved observable temporal compliance in the generated literature reviews.

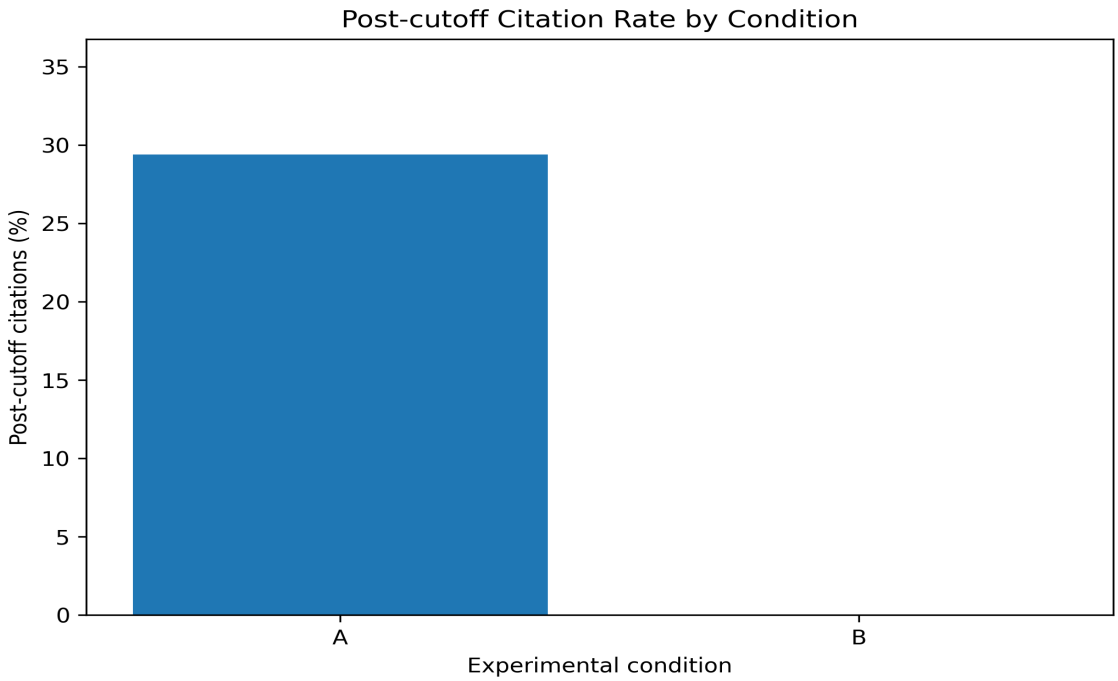


Figure 1. Overall post-cutoff citation rates

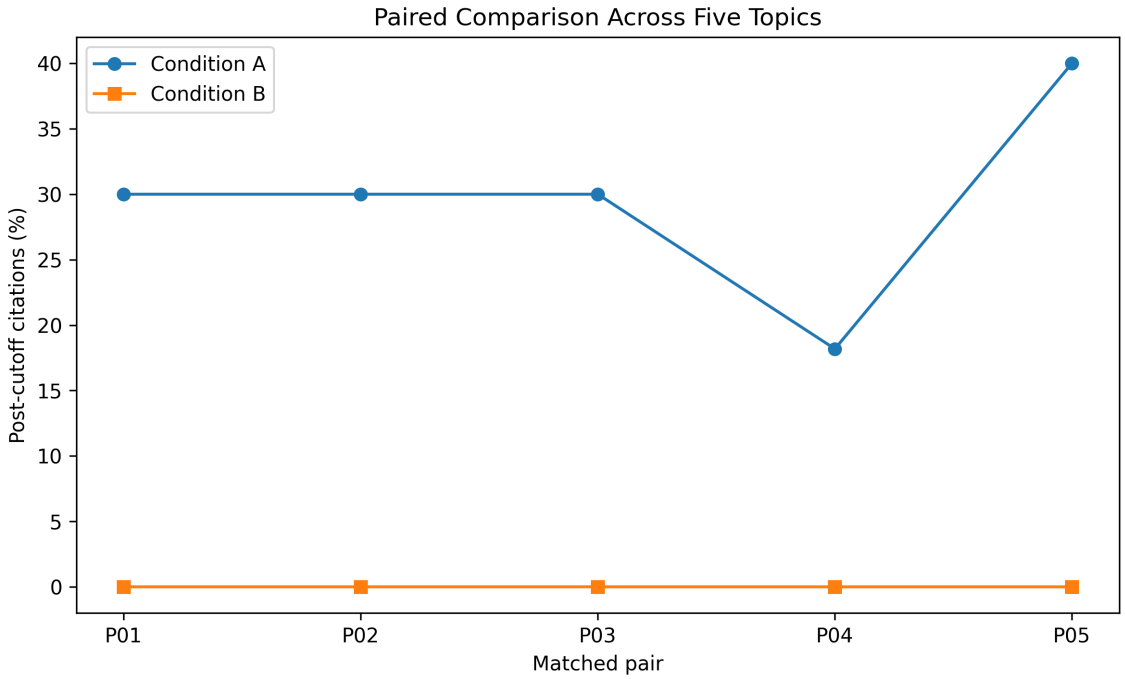


Figure 2. Paired comparison across five topics

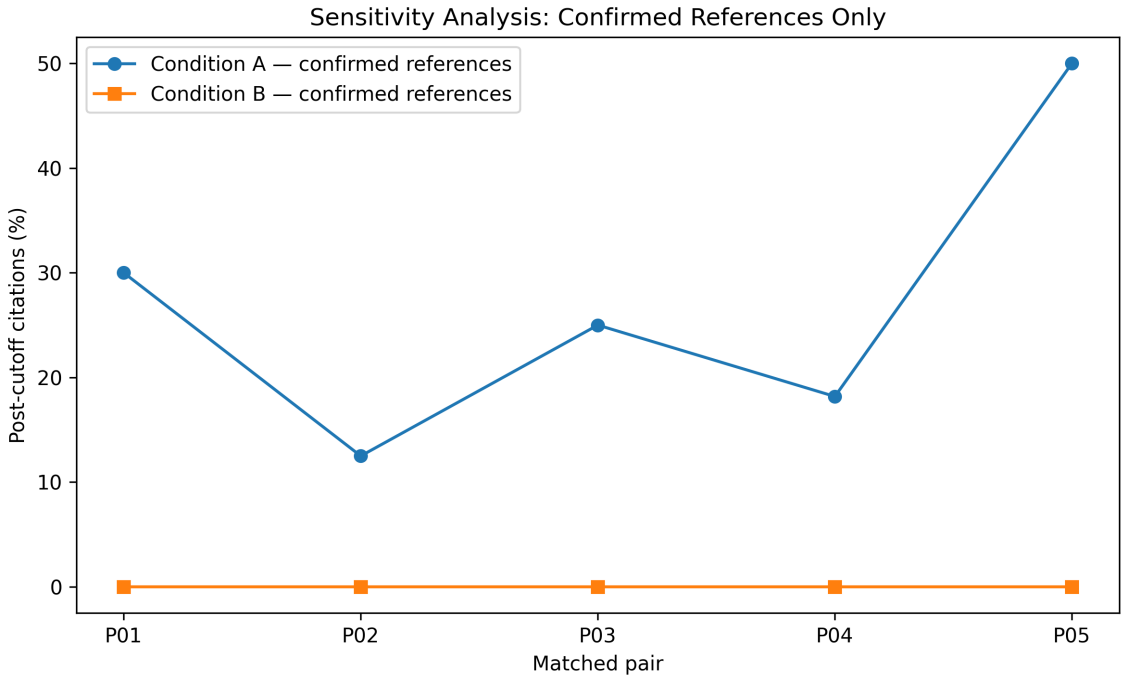


Figure 3. Sensitivity analysis using confirmed references

5. Discussion

5.1 Interpretation of the Findings

The findings indicate that adding an explicit publication-date boundary instruction was associated with improved temporal compliance in the generated literature reviews.

Condition A produced 15 post-cutoff citation instances among 51 references, whereas Condition B produced none among 48 references. The observed difference was 29.41 percentage points.

Importantly, this pattern was consistent across all five matched pairs. The sensitivity analysis, which retained only references classified as bibliographic matches, also showed a reduction. Its mean paired reduction was 27.14 percentage points.

These results suggest that a clearly stated temporal constraint can influence the publication dates of references selected or generated during literature-review generation.

5.2 Implications for Literature Review Generation

The findings have practical implications for researchers using large language models to support literature reviews.

A model may produce a plausible-looking bibliography without necessarily respecting a researcher's intended temporal scope. An explicit cutoff instruction may help reduce this problem.

However, a date instruction should not replace independent bibliographic verification. Researchers should still check titles, authors, publication venues, DOIs, and the distinction between preprint and formally published versions.

A useful research workflow should therefore combine explicit prompt constraints with external reference verification.

5.3 Bibliographic Reliability

Condition B also showed a higher bibliographic match rate in this sample. However, this result should be interpreted cautiously.

The experiment was not designed with a sufficiently large sample to establish that explicit temporal instructions generally improve bibliographic accuracy. The observed difference may be influenced by the small number of generated reviews, the topics selected, and the unresolved partial-match cases.

Temporal compliance and bibliographic correctness should therefore

be treated as separate dimensions of citation reliability.

5.4 Relationship to Knowledge Boundaries

The experiment evaluates whether a model follows an explicitly provided publication-date boundary. It does not directly reveal the model's internal training-data cutoff or establish when the model acquired particular information.

A model can cite a post-cutoff work because of information available through its context, retrieval, updates, or other mechanisms. Likewise, a model can omit a recent work even if it has information about that work.

Consequently, the results concern observable temporal instruction compliance rather than the model's internal knowledge boundary.

6. Limitations

6.1 Small Sample Size

The experiment included five matched pairs and ten literature reviews. This limited sample restricts statistical power and generalizability.

The descriptive consistency across pairs is encouraging, but larger studies are needed to determine whether the observed pattern holds across different models, domains, and prompts.

6.2 Single Model Interface

The reviews were generated manually through the ChatGPT interface. The findings should not automatically be generalized to other models, model versions, APIs, or generation settings.

6.3 Review Length Deviation

The generated reviews exceeded the originally intended target of 800–1,000 words. This deviation was documented, and the original outputs were retained rather than edited after generation.

Differences in review length may have influenced the number of

references produced.

6.4 Bibliographic Uncertainty

Although 93 entries were classified as MATCH, five were classified as PARTIAL_MATCH and one as DOI_MISMATCH.

Automated metadata services may return incomplete records, and preprint and publication versions can have different dates or identifiers. These cases require careful interpretation.

6.5 Publication Date Versus Internal Knowledge

The experiment measured compliance with an explicit publication-date constraint. It did not measure the model's internal knowledge cutoff, training-data composition, or exact knowledge acquisition dates.

6.6 Limited Statistical Generalizability

Only five paired comparisons were available. The two-sided exact sign test yielded $p = 0.0625$, which does not meet the conventional 0.05 threshold.

The results should therefore be presented as preliminary, descriptive evidence rather than definitive statistical proof.

7. Conclusion

This study investigated whether an explicit publication-date boundary instruction influences the temporal compliance of large language models when generating literature reviews.

Across five matched prompt pairs, the standard prompting condition produced a post-cutoff citation rate of 29.41%, while the condition containing an explicit publication-date boundary produced a rate of 0%.

The mean paired reduction was 29.64 percentage points. A sensitivity analysis restricted to bibliographically matched references also showed a reduction, with a mean paired difference of

27.14 percentage points.

The findings suggest that explicitly stating a publication-date boundary may be a useful practical measure for reducing post-cutoff citations in generated literature reviews.

Nevertheless, temporal instruction compliance does not guarantee bibliographic accuracy. Independent verification remains necessary, particularly when references involve preprints, later proceedings, or uncertain publication metadata.

Future research should examine larger samples, multiple language models, different academic domains, and repeated generations under controlled settings. Such work could provide stronger evidence about the reliability of temporal constraints in AI-assisted academic research.

Overall, this study provides preliminary evidence that explicit temporal instructions can improve observable date-boundary compliance, while highlighting the continuing need for independent citation verification.

Appendix A: Extracted Bibliographic References

The following entries are reproduced from the generated reviews. They are grouped by experimental run. Bibliographic verification decisions are recorded separately in the citation audit dataset.

P01_A

• Lazaridou, A., et al. (2021). Mind the Gap: Assessing Temporal Generalization in Neural Language Models. Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS 2021). URL: https://proceedings.neurips.cc/paper_files/paper/2021/hash/f5bf0ba0a17ef18f9607774722f5698c-Abstract.html [Audit: MATCH]

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• Mugaanyi, J., Cai, L., Cheng, S., Lu, C., & Huang, J. (2024). Evaluation of Large Language Model Performance and Reliability for Citations and References in Scholarly Writing: Cross-Disciplinary Study. Journal of Medical Internet Research, 26, e52935. DOI: https://doi.org/10.2196/52935 [Audit: MATCH]

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• Zhu, Z., Liao, Y., Chen, Z., Wang, Y., Guan, Y., Wang, Y., & Wang, Y. (2025). EvolveBench: A Comprehensive Benchmark for Assessing Temporal Awareness in LLMs on Evolving Knowledge. Proceedings of the 63rd Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics, 16173–16188. DOI: https://doi.org/10.18653/v1/2025.acl-long.788 [Audit: MATCH]

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• Huang, L., et al. (2025). A Survey on Hallucination in Large Language Models: Principles, Taxonomy, Challenges, and Open Questions. ACM Transactions on Information Systems, 43(2), Article 42. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1145/3703155 Bibliographic note: The references above were checked against publisher, conference, or scholarly indexing records where available. For the Dhingra and Lazaridou papers, stable publisher or proceedings URLs are supplied rather than an unverified DOI. The Lewis and Huang entries use abbreviated author lists; consult the publisher records for complete author metadata. Literature coverage is selective rather than exhaustive. [Audit: MATCH]

P01_B

• Lin, S., Hilton, J., & Evans, O. (2022). TruthfulQA: Measuring How Models Mimic Human Falsehoods. Proceedings of the 60th Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics (ACL), 3214–3252. DOI: 10.18653/v1/2022.acl-long.229 [Audit: MATCH]

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P02_A

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P02_B

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